Prompt Structure Template

AI Literacy for the Modern Workforce

Use this template to structure any AI prompt. Organized by the three Description sub-components. Most underspecified prompts fail on all three simultaneously. Workers who can spot a flawed output often cannot steer the model to a better one (72 of 319 in Lee et al., CHI 2025, p. 11); the scaffold below is for that step. *Use it as a structural scaffold for any task, not a prompt library.*

PRODUCT DESCRIPTION

What do you want?

Define the output before you request it.

SPECIFY...	ASK YOURSELF...
Format	What form should this take? (memo, email, table, analysis, code, slide outline...)
Audience	Who will read this? What do they already know? What do they need?
Length	How long? (word count, number of items, page count, compression level)
Detail level	Overview or deep dive? Executive summary or technical spec?
Quality criteria	What standard must it meet? (style guide, accuracy threshold, specific requirements)

FILL IN

"I need a [format] for [audience] that is approximately [length] and covers [scope] at [detail level]. It must [quality criteria]."

PROCESS DESCRIPTION

How should AI approach this?

Guide the method, not just the destination.

SPECIFY...	ASK YOURSELF...
Steps / sequence	Analyze then recommend? Compare X to Y? Work through a framework?
Methods	Use a specific model? (your rubric, SWOT, scoring matrix, regulatory checklist)
Constraints	What boundaries? (only this data source, this time period, exclude these topics)
Include / exclude	What must it cover? What should it skip?
Reasoning	Show its reasoning? Work step by step? Present alternatives first?

FILL IN

"Approach this by [method]. Use [framework] as structure. Constrain to [boundaries]. Include [required] and exclude [out-of-scope]."

PERFORMANCE DESCRIPTION

How should AI behave?

Shape the interaction, not just the output.

SPECIFY...	ASK YOURSELF...
Tone	Direct and actionable? Diplomatic? Analytical? Conversational?
Voice	Expert consultant? Knowledgeable peer? Supportive instructor? Neutral reporter?
Directness	Tell me what to do? Present options? Challenge my assumptions?
Priorities	Brevity or completeness? Speed or thoroughness? Creativity or precision?
What to avoid	Hedging language? Generic disclaimers? Overly formal register?

FILL IN

"Use a [tone] tone. Write as a [voice]. Be [directness]. Prioritize [priority]. Avoid [what to avoid]."

AFTER THE FIRST OUTPUT: THE DESCRIPTION–DISCERNMENT LOOP

Evaluate what comes back using the same three dimensions, identify which has the largest gap, then revise that dimension and regenerate.

Product: Does the output match your format, audience, and length specification?

Process: Is the structure and reasoning approach what you asked for?

Performance: Does the tone, voice, and register fit?

Framework: 4D AI Fluency Framework, Description competency (Dakan & Feller, 2025, pp. 4–5), as taught in Anthropic's AI Fluency course.

© Michael Ritchot. Code licensed under the MIT License. Instructional content licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.